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Leader-Member Exchange Quality: An Empirical Investigation in Restaurants

R. Thomas George
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ABSTRACT. Leader-member exchange (LMX) is a multidimensional construct seeking to identify the quality of the relationship between the leader and immediate subordinate. An instrument developed by Schriesheim, Neider, Scandura, and Tepper (1992) was utilized to determine the LMX score of 798 non-managerial employees in a casual restaurant chain. The dimensions of perceived contribution, affect, and loyalty were examined. Results demonstrate that LMX quality was high among the surveyed employees of a restaurant chain. The scores of LMX on age, gender and job tenure differed among employees while LMX scores on job status, education, and job type did not differ significantly. *[Article copies available for a fee from The Haworth Document Delivery Service: 1-800-HAWORTH. E-mail address: <docdelivery@haworthpress.com> Website: <<http://www.HaworthPress.com>> © 2004 by The Haworth Press, Inc. All rights reserved.]*

KEYWORDS. LMX, leader-member relations, manager-employee relationships

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INTRODUCTION

The relationship an employee has with his or her supervisor is “. . . a lens through which the entire work experience is viewed.” (Gerstner and Day 1997, p. 840)

In the hospitality industry, employees are deemed to be a significant asset to the company, as they are seen to be the instruments delivering service to the profit-generating customer. Schneider (1980) has suggested that the relationship between the manager and the employees has an effect on the service climate that is felt by the customers. Therefore, a high quality relationship between managers and employees should have a positive impact on employee performance. The customers reflect this outcome as well. When a customer walks away from a service-providing organization, his or her emotion about the organization largely depends on the employees' behavior (Zeelenberg & Pieters, 1999). The customer's emotions can be described as either pleased and satisfied, or annoyed and victimized. The former is always the expected output for any organization to survive.

Employees, especially new recruits, need to understand the expectations and values of the manager as well as the strategies followed by the organization. The development of the functional role and understanding of superordinate support is important in defining the future contribution of the employee. The perception and response of the employee is important in the development of the “exchange relationship.”

The relationship between employee and supervisor has long been the subject of investigation. As a result of this study, a wide variety of models of leadership and explanations of the relationship have been formulated (Bass, 1990; Yukl, 2002). The relationship becomes more challenging when the parties have a very close working relationship as in the restaurant industry. Here, managers often have a very direct involvement in the selection, training and direction of employees. They often work alongside the employees and assist in the performance of many of their duties. The quality of the relationship often has much to do with the success of the establishment.

Many of the early leadership studies focused on the leader and sought to explain effective leadership using a trait, skills or style approach. While the approaches varied, it was often suggested that using a similar or average leadership style (ALS) among all employees might be considered as “consistency in leadership.” These approaches suggested that the proper mixes of “consideration” and “initiating structure” would as-

sure a consistent style toward all subordinates (Stogill & Coons, 1957). The approach was popularized by Blake and Mouton (1964) and others at the time. Other investigations concentrated on the follower and the context resulting in situational, contingency and path-goal theories. A variety of situational and contingency theories followed. Cogliser and Schriesheim (2000) suggest that Fiedler's Contingency Model (Fiedler, 1967) may help explain the relationship between leadership style and group effectiveness. The model also explores the relationship between several factors such as task structure, position power, trust, affect, respect, and loyalty between the members of the leader-subordinate dyad as they interact and form relationships.

LMX quality theory, on the other hand, uses a different approach in explaining supervisor-subordinate interaction. Basic concepts of Vertical Dyad Linkage theory (VDL), the forerunner of LMX, evolved out of the work of Dansereau, Graen, and Cashman, (1973), Dansereau, Graen, and Haga, (1975), and Cashman, Dansereau, Graen and Haga (1976). This approach suggested that leaders divide their subordinates into in-groups and out-groups and become leaders of the in-group members but not necessarily of the out-group members. VDL theory suggested that the relationship between leaders and subordinates occurs in such a way that the idea of supportiveness and openness between two parties becomes prominent. The VDL model has since been extended to include the ALS and reconceptualized as a new model of "individualized" leadership (Dansereau, 1995). The notion of subordinate self-worth and individualized treatment by the superordinate became central to the individualized approach to leadership (Dansereau, Yammarino et al., 1995).

A second approach to the development of VDL came to be called Leader-Member Exchange (LMX) (Graen, Novak, & Summerkamp, 1982). Leader member exchange is defined as "(a) system of components and their relationships (b) involving both members of a dyad (i.e., the relationship between a leader and each of his/her subordinates), (c) involving interdependent patterns of behavior, (d) sharing mutual outcome instrumentalities and (e) producing conceptions of environments causing maps and value" (Scandura, Graen, & Novak, 1986, p. 580).

According to the LMX theory, leaders differentiate between subordinates and develop a different type of relationship or exchange (Graen & Cashman, 1975; Liden & Graen, 1980) with the subordinates. It was hypothesized that there were two categories of the relationship. The "in-group" held a high quality relationship with the leader and thus received more attention and opportunity. Subordinates in this group

sought to become more involved, expand their role and took on extra responsibility within the unit. A transformational style of leadership might be implemented for those in this group. The other was the “out-group” having a lower quality relationship and performing the more routine duties with a more strict style of supervision. This group represented the implementation of a more formal employment contract and a transactional leadership style most often being implemented. The theory also suggests that the leadership process becomes more efficient when the leaders and members establish a high quality relationship.

Graen and Scandura (1987) suggested the exchange has three parts. The first part being an initial testing period in which the supervisor and employee begin to examine and evaluate the motives, attitudes, and resources available to be exchanged. The relationship may then proceed to second phase in which the superordinate-subordinate relationship begins grow in trust and loyalty leading to increased respect. Should the relationship continue to grow, there is increased mutual commitment to the goals and mission of the organization. Graen and Uhl-Bien (1991) and Uhl-Bien and Graen (1992) referred to this progression as a process for leadership making and described it as a “life-cycle of leadership maturity” (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995, p. 230). The three phases were named, in order of progression, stranger, acquaintance, and maturity.

Since its introduction, the literature exploring LMX quality has been expanding with research focusing on various aspects of organizational variables and outcomes related to the quality of the LMX relationship. Novak and Graen (1987) examined the relationship of selected leader resources (control, trust, and expertise) and LMX quality. They found that leader control moderated the relationship between trust and LMX and between leader expertise and LMX. For a compensatory role of control in the trust- LMX relationship, when trust in the leader was low, perceived control did not make a significant difference in the quality of the exchange (Novak & Graen, 1987). In exploring the relationship between LMX quality and selected organizational variables, Kozlowski and Doherty (1989) found a positive relationship between LMX and work structure, job understanding, responsibility, supervisor work emphasis, teamwork, inter-group cooperation, and management awareness and concern. Scott and Bruce (1994) indicate that LMX has a positive relationship with the organization’s support for innovation and creativity. Examining organizational influences on LMX and resulting outcomes, Green, Anderson and Shivers (1996) found a negative relationship between LMX quality and work unit size, and a positive relationship between LMX and organization net income. High quality LMX has also

been found to have positive relationships with increased job satisfaction and organizational commitment (Gerstner & Day, 1997), reduced turnover (Graen, Liden & Hoel, 1982) and employee empowerment (Sparrowe, 1995).

LMX has been conceptualized as multidimensional in nature. While Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995) suggest respect, trust, and obligation as sub-dimensions, Liden and Maslyn (1998) propose loyalty, affect, contribution, and professional respect as the underlying constructs. Schriesheim and his colleagues' study of LMX quality produced three dimensions—perceived contribution loyalty, and affect (Schriesheim, Scandura, Eisenbach, & Neider, 1992). Each of the dimensions of this last group is briefly discussed, as they are central to the present study.

Perceived contribution in the LMX context is the importance of the subordinate's job to the supervisor and the subordinate's ability to perform the job well. The assumption is that the contribution of a subordinate to the leader-member exchange process depends upon the centrality of the subordinate's job to unit performance and on the degree to which the subordinate is capable of performing his or her job well (Graen & Scandura, 1987). Subordinates' work related behaviors are important in developing higher quality LMX. Higher quality means greater exchange of valued resources between leader and member (Bass, 1990). Among these valued resources, budgetary support, equipment, information, and attractive task assignments may be included.

Loyalty is defined as the extent to which both leader and member publicly support each other's actions and character. The critical aspect of LMX loyalty emphasizes perceived goal congruence and being a good team member (Dienesch & Liden, 1986, p. 625). It is claimed that tasks requiring independent judgment and responsibility are to be performed by the loyal members (Scandura et al., 1986).

Affect refers to "the mutual affection members of the dyad have for each other based primarily on interpersonal attraction rather than work or professional values (Dienesch, & Liden, 1986, p. 625). In the measurement of the "affect" dimension of LMX quality," Schriesheim and his colleagues consider that affect means satisfaction with supervisor human relations and satisfaction with supervisor technical ability. These two concepts are believed to be the characterizing elements of leader-follower interaction (Schriesheim et al., 1992).

Since its introduction, the theory has evolved over the years (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995). The construct's theoretical foundations, research methodology, and implications have been reviewed by Dienesch and Liden (1986), Graen and Scandura, (1987), Liden and Maslyn (1998),

and Schriesheim, Castro, and Cogliser (1999). Schriesheim, Castro, Zhou, and Yammarino (2002) commented on the level of analysis utilized in examining LMX.

LMX RESEARCH IN HOSPITALITY INDUSTRY

Although the LMX concept has received widespread use and discussion in a variety of industries, it has only received only limited examination in the hospitality industry. Sparrowe suggests that the effects of leadership and the quality of supervision can be captured by the Leader Member Exchange (LMX) theory, which is a measure of the differential relationships between supervisors and employees within a work group that captures the variance in outcomes resulting from dyadic processes (Sparrowe, 1995, p. 97).

Sparrowe (1994) states that service employees, whose relationships with their supervisors are positive, will generate feelings of having meaningful work, competence, and impact on their jobs. His study of over thirty-three different hospitality organizations in 1994 and 1995 reveals that a positive relationship between subordinate and the immediate supervisor is a significant element in the development of feelings of empowerment, commitment and high quality LMX (Sparrowe, 1994, 1995).

Using a sample of non-managerial hospitality employees, Borchgrevink (1993) found a strong relationship between LMX quality and Maslach's (Maslach, 1982) three dimensions of burnout (emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishments). Borchgrevink and Boster (1994) found a positive relationship between two LMX factors (relational estimates of the superior-subordinate exchange relationship and an indicator of in-group status, p. 90) and job communication and non-job communication among hospitality workers. They also found a positive relationship between a subordinate's communicative responsiveness and LMX. To further explore antecedents of LMX, Borchgrevink and Boster (1997) tested the relationship between wide range of constructs and LMX. They found that superior-subordinate interdyadic communication, that is, the superior's coercive power and superior's reward power were antecedents of LMX.

Testa (2002) utilized the concepts of LMX in the investigation of supervisor-employee relationships in the cruise industry. His findings supported the notion in that congruent groups (high LMX) there was a higher level of consideration behaviors, trust, and higher levels of satis-

faction with their supervisor. Examining a variety of factors related to employee socialization, Lam (2003) found that a higher quality LMX produced a lower level of turnover intention among new employees in the Hong Kong hospitality industry.

The literature review shows the LMX concept has been used in the investigation of a number of factors relating to hospitality employees. The findings support the continuation of this study to help better understand the nature of the superordinate-subordinate relationship. The goal of the present study was to further examine LMX theory as related to restaurant employees and to offer suggestions as to improving the exchange relationship. Consequently, this study had three purposes. The first purpose was to determine the level of perceived LMX of employees working in casual restaurants. Second it was to determine if there were differences in perceived LMX of employees when examined by age, gender, job tenure, job type, and job status. The third purpose was to determine the relation of three dimensions of LMX on LMX. These dimensions being: perceived contribution, loyalty, and affect.

METHOD

The sample for this study was drawn from the employees of a regional restaurant chain located in a midwestern portion of the United States. At the time of the study, the chain employed more than 4,500 people in 54 restaurants with approximately 4000 in the non-supervisory positions. Nearly forty percent of these 4000 employees were targeted for the study, resulting in a study population of 1560.

A letter explaining the nature of the study was sent to each restaurant along with a support letter from the corporate office, indicating permission to distribute the survey to the employees working in each restaurant. The general managers of each restaurant carried out the distribution and collection of the surveys. Questionnaires were to be distributed to a randomized sample of employees on duty at the restaurants. The anonymously completed questionnaire was to be placed in an individual envelope, sealed and returned to the researcher. Individual participant confidentiality was assured.

For the purposes of this study, Leader Member Exchange quality was assessed using a six-item LMX-6 scale developed by Schriesheim, Neider, Scandura, and Tepper (1992). The three components, perceived contribution, loyalty, and affect, were identified by two questionnaire items each. Scores from the six items are summed and then divided by six

to obtain an average score for the leader member exchange quality scale. Schriesheim et al. (1992) tested the scale with two independent samples and retested in two other samples. Correcting these test and retest coefficients for measurement and reliability gave excellent reliabilities of .96 and .99 for the two samples. Convergent and discriminant validity of the LMX scale were also supported in other studies (Schriesheim, Liden, Maslyn, Coglisier, & Williams, 1997; Schriesheim, Scandura, Eisenbach, & Neider 1992).

RESULTS

Descriptive statistics were computed for analyzing the characteristics of the respondents and are displayed in Table 1. Among 1580 surveys instruments sent, total of 798 useable instruments were received from 52 restaurants representing 50.5% response rate. Female employees accounted for nearly 62% of the respondents and male employees 38%. The respondent mean age was 26 with a mean tenure of 2.5 years of experience in the establishment. The percent of employees indicating some college background was 52.8%, while remaining subjects divided into those having some high school education (5.1%); being a high school graduate (24.1%); college graduates (16.3%) and those having a graduate degree (1.8%). Part-time workers accounted for one-third of the respondents with two-thirds indicating full-time status. Nearly 71% of the respondents were waiters and waitresses, 14% were cooks, 5.4% were bartenders, and the remaining 9.4% indicated that they were working a variety of positions.

The differences between the scores of LMX on demographics were computed conducting a series of t-tests and ANOVAs. The t-tests and ANOVAs revealed that a significant difference exists for the LMX mean scores based on age ($F(5,771) = 8.6, p \leq .05$), gender ($F(2, 780) = 1.91, p \leq .05$) and job tenure ($F(5,777) = 3.18, p \leq .05$). LMX scores on job status, education, and job type did not differ significantly.

Pairwise comparisons were computed using Post-Hoc analysis for statistically significant variables. As suggested by Howell (1992), Fisher's Least Significant Difference Test (LSD) was employed. Employees aged 32 and above had higher LMX scores than did the younger employees. Female employee's mean LMX scores were higher than those of males. Employees whose job tenure was from 1-2 years had lower scores of LMX than the other job tenure categories.

TABLE 1. Demographics of Respondents and Overall LMX Scores

Characteristics	N ^a	Percent (%)	LMX Score ^b
Age:			
Less than 19 years old	128	16.5	23.33
20-25	362	46.6	23.53
26-31	135	17.4	23.70
32-37	66	8.5	24.92*
38-43	51	6.6	26.14*
44 years and older	35	4.5	26.11*
Gender:			
Male	300	38.4	23.63
Female	482	61.6	24.16*
Education:			
Some high school	40	5.1	23.23
High school graduate	188	24.1	24.02
Some college/technical	412	52.8	23.92
College graduate	127	16.3	23.99
Graduate degree	14	1.8	24.71
Job tenure:			
Less than 3 months	111	14.3	24.68
3 months to less than 1 year	211	27.1	24.24
1-2 years	144	18.5	23.53
2-5 years	210	27.0	23.37*
5-10 years	71	9.1	24.01
10 years and higher	31	4.0	25.23
Job type:			
Waiter/Waitresses	555	71.2	23.93
Cook	109	14.0	23.38
Bartender	42	5.4	24.57
Variety of Positions	73	9.4	24.58
Job status:			
Part time	262	33.5	24.02
Full time	519	66.5	23.93

^aTotal N varies (lowest 777- highest 782) among groups because of the missing values

^bPossible Range 6-30

* Significant at $p < .05$

The dimensions of perceived contribution, loyalty, and affect and their relation to LMX are shown in Table 2. Each of the dimensions had a high mean score and was significantly correlated to the computed LMX score. Furthermore, all of the dimensions were moderately correlated to each other.

For the total of 787 employees responding to the survey, the scores of leader member exchange quality were classified using a statistical technique referred to as k-means clustering. Gupta (1999) suggests that k-means clustering can be used when there are no pre-defined cut-off values for creating a categorical variable from a continuous variable.

TABLE 2. Means, Standard Deviations and Intercorrelations of LMX and Subdimension Scales

Dimension	Mean	SD	1	2	3
Perceived Contribution	8.16	1.28			
Loyalty	8.05	1.52	.45		
Affect	7.73	1.78	.47	.58	
LMX	23.94	3.78	.74	.83	.87

All correlations are significant at $p < .01$

N = 798

Range for perceived contribution, loyalty and affect is between 2-10

Range for LMX is 6-30

After analysis, three categories of LMX scores were derived. As shown in Table 3, 48.5% of the employees were classified as having a high LMX score, 43% as having an LMX score in the middle range, with 8.5% in the low LMX score range. SPSS 10th edition is the statistical package used in the study.

DISCUSSION

The purpose of this study was to assess LMX quality among restaurant employees. Graen (1976) suggests that the quality of interpersonal relationship between leader and subordinate is crucial. When employees understand their jobs clearly and receive higher support from their managers, they will assume more responsibility, and feel more satisfied and empowered.

In contrast to the original "favorable" and "unfavorable" grouping of scores, this study identified three clusters of respondents. A high LMX score was indicated by 48.5% of the employees. A middle category is comprised of 43% of the employees with 8.5% placing in a low LMX score category. The identification of three groups was consistent with Uhl-Bien and Maslyn (2000). They named the clusters, in descending LMX score, as generalized reciprocity (the second largest group), balanced reciprocity (the largest group), and negative reciprocity (the smallest group). Sparrowe and Liden (1997) discussed the nature of reciprocity utilizing the same terms. The interest dimension (concern for others, mutuality, and self-interest) is useful in explaining the orientation of the employees in each category. This orientation may have a sig-

TABLE 3. Categorized LMX Scores: Low, Average, and High

Low Leader Member Exchange	
Cluster Center	16
# of cases in each group	67
Percentage (%)	8.5
Average Leader Member Exchange	
Cluster Center	22
# of cases in each group	339
Percentage (%)	43
High Leader Member Exchange	
Cluster Center	27
# of cases in each group	381
Percentage (%)	48.5

N = 787

Range for LMX is 6-30

nificant impact on future performance. It may be that the first two groups are the “in-group” and the “out-group” and the third is a disgruntled outlier group. Or it may be that the middle group is in transition and will move to either the first or last group, depending to their negotiated relationship. Uhl-Bien and Maslyn (2000) believe that as individuals move from a level of lower quality relationship to one of a higher quality there will be a transformation from self-interest to partnership interest. It is suggested that additional study be conducted to examine the nature of employee progress in this grouping and its impact on performance. The nature of these results may be a result of the close working relationship between managers and subordinate within the restaurant industry.

The high correlations between each of the three dimensions studied and LMX suggests their importance in developing a high quality LMX relationship. It is noted that previously mentioned studies have found the importance of additional dimensions (Liden & Maslyn, 1998), further study will aid in developing and applying the LMX model. It is suggested that understanding the contributors to a high quality relationship will aid in the development of the relationship between the superordinate and the subordinate. Recognizing the contributions of employees, supporting performance, and demonstrating a positive feeling for the employees will assist in furthering this relationship.

Managers may believe they treat all employees the same, however employee perceptions indicate something else. In examining the demographics, the LMX scores of older employees and females were found to

be significantly higher than their comparison groups, while employees whose job tenure was between 1-2 years had lower LMX scores than those in other job tenure categories. Larwood and Blackmore (1978) reported that the gender mix of the supervisor-subordinate dyad has a significant impact on the resultant quality of exchange. Green, Anderson, and Shivers (1996) also found gender to be an influencing factor.

Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995, 1991) suggest the use of LMX theory be considered as a Leadership Making Model. The model describes a process for generating more high quality relationships between leaders and individual employees within organizations. Within a hospitality establishment, the model might be used to assist managers in better understanding the process by which subordinates will make decisions concerning their advancement from the "stranger" to "acquaintance" and "maturity" stages identified by Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995). They further suggest the expansion of the dyadic relationship to groups and teams.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

This study acknowledges several limitations. One, it was conducted using employees from one restaurant chain. However, the subjects are representative of those working in similar chains, thus generalizability is enhanced. A larger and more diverse subject base might give different results. Second, the survey instrument was given to employees by the unit managers. Here, an assumption is made that it was given without bias. Third, only non-managerial employees were included in the study. It would be useful to make comparisons as to how managers responded in relation to their supervisors.

Increased use of the LMX model will lead to greater understanding of the relationship between superordinates and subordinates. The results of this study demonstrate that there is much to do in the examination of leader member relations in the hospitality industry. Additional comparison of LMX scores with individual productivity and unit profitability would provide useful information. Additional information might also be used in the training and development of future managers. The consistent use of the same LMX instrument would be of value in making comparison studies. Using different instruments may lead to differing results and interpretation. Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995) make a case for the seven-item instrument they have developed and their "Leadership Making Model."

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